

Curriculum Vitae - Kseniia Harshina

Personal Information

Field	Details
Name	Kseniia Harshina
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LinkedIn	Profile Link
Google Scholar	Profile Link

Education

Degree	Institution	Years	Thesis Topic
PhD (Ongoing)	University of Klagenfurt	2024 - Present	Developing a Video Game for Empathy Enhancement and Empowerment Taking in the Context of Forced Migration Experiences
M.Sc. Game Studies & Engineering	University of Klagenfurt	2020 - 2023	Generating UAV Countermeasures Using Machine Learning: A Game-Based Approach
B.Sc. Software Engineering	NTU Ukraine	2017 - 2020	Project Management Web Application for Volunteering Projects

Work Experience

Position	Institution	Years	Key Responsibilities
University Assistant (Pre-Doc Researcher)	University of Klagenfurt	2024 - Present	Research on Game Design for Empathy and Empowerment for People with Experiences of Forced Migration
Junior Researcher (Part-time Student Employee)	Lakeside Labs GmbH	2021 - 2023	Research in AI, reinforcement learning, and swarm intelligence

Additional Training & Schools

Program	Institution	Year
Spring School on Social XR	University of Amsterdam	2024
Summer School on Games and AI	University of Malta	2024

Teaching

Role	Institution	Years	Key Responsibilities
Lecturer – <i>Representation and Configuration in Games: Perspectives</i>	University of Klagenfurt	2024-Present	Designed and taught a full semester course on representation, perspectives, and game studies methodologies. Implemented accessibility-focused teaching practices.

Research Areas & Interests

Category	Details
Game Studies & Narrative Analysis	Research on catharsis, adaptation, and emergent storytelling in games.
Participatory & Community-Based Research	Game Jam for People with Forced Migration Experience; Co-design methodologies.
Psychological Approaches in Game Studies	Intersection of gameplay, empathy, and mental health.
AI & Machine Learning in Games	Generative AI, reinforcement learning, and game analytics.

Community & Public Engagement

Initiative	Role	Years	Key Contributions
Games Intersectional	Founder & Organizer	2023 - Present	Established a community for marginalized voices in game studies and industry. Organized events and meetups.
Proposal Writing Workshop	Organizer & Teacher	2024	Organized a two-month workshop for master students on introduction to independent funding
MORE Program	Student Representative	2022 - 2023	Assisted refugee and displaced students in accessing higher education resources.

Initiative	Role	Years	Key Contributions
Game Jam for People with Forced Migration Experience	Organizer & Researcher	2025 (Upcoming)	Designed a participatory research-based game jam, integrating storytelling and community engagement.
Women in Data Science Villach	Speaker	2023	Talk on <i>Using Data Analytics in Game Development</i>
Games & Language Conference	Speaker	2023	<i>AI and Player Agency in Game Narrative</i>

Recent Publications

Authors	Title	Conference/Journal	Year
Harshina, Harbig, Lux, Tucek	Experiencing Forced Migration: A Participatory Approach to Developing a Serious Video Game	International Conference on Games and Learning Alliance	2024
Harbig, Harshina	For Empowerment’s Sake: Rethinking Video Game Adaptations of Real-Life Experiences	Games and Narrative International Conference (ICGaN 2025)	2025
Tucek, Harshina, Samaritaki, Rajesh	One Spell Fits All: A Generative AI Game as a Tool for Research in AI Creativity and Sustainable Design	Proceedings of the Experimental Artificial Intelligence in Games (EXAG 2024) Workshop	2024
Harshina	Developing a Virtual-Reality Game for Empathy Enhancement and Perspective-Taking in the Context of Forced Migration Experiences	CHI PLAY Companion Proceedings	2024
Harshina	In the Ring and on the Runway: Masculinities of Drag and Wrestling from TV to Video Games	Play/Write Student Journal	2024
Harshina, Tucek	Unraveling the Normalization of Colonial, Imperial, and Authoritarian Narratives in Modern Video Games	Future Reality of Gaming 2024	2024
Simonjan, Harshina, Schranz	Reinforcement Learning-Based Countermeasures Against Attacking UAV Swarms	19th International Conference on Distributed Computing in Smart Systems and the Internet of Things (DCOSS-IoT)	2023

Grants, Funding and Awards Applications

Grant / Funding	Institution	Year	Status
Ada Lovelace Research Grant	University of Klagenfurt	2024	Awarded
Identity Jam Grant (UNESCO Chair)	GEPARD / UNESCO	2023	Awarded
Games Intersectional (UNESCO Chair)	GEPARD/UNESCO	2024	Awarded

Grant / Funding	Institution	Year	Status
University of Klagenfurt Technology Scholarship	OeAD	2020-2021	Awarded
AI and Games Summer School Scholarship, 2 nd Place in Game Jam	AI and Games Summer School	2024	Awarded
Game Jam for People with Forced Migration Experience	Research Service of University of Klagenfurt	2025	Applied

Technical Skills

Category	Skills
Programming	Python, C#, ASP.NET
Game Engines	Unity, Ren'Py, RPG Maker
AI & Machine Learning	Reinforcement Learning, OpenAI Gym, Swarm Intelligence
Research Methods	Survey Design, Quantitative & Qualitative Analysis

Game Title	Role	Year	Achievement
One Spell Fits All	Designer & Developer	2024	2nd Place at Summer School Game Jam; accepted at FDG 2025 Games and Demo track
Monster Match	Designer	2023	10k+ views & 6k browser plays on Itch.io
UI & Chill	Designer	2022	1st Place (Creativity), 3rd Place (Overall, Aesthetics, Fun)
Curse of the Narrator	Designer	2022	2nd Place (Overall, Game Design, Presentation)
Slay, Princess, Get Your Drag On	Designer	2023	Game Jam project exploring AI & identity